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RSO Funding Resources



Funding can help your organization transform ideas into meaningful experiences and opportunities for students. This page is your guide to the ASMSU funding process, providing Registered Student Organizations (RSOs) with the information needed to successfully apply for and manage funding. Whether you're submitting your first request or need a refresher, you'll find resources on funding opportunities, timelines, policies, spending guidelines, and best practices to help your organization make the most of its allocated funds.

Every fee-paying student contributes **\$11.13 per semester** through the Student Organization Fee. These fees support two funding programs available to eligible RSOs: Rolling Funding and Volunteer & Impact Montana (VIM) Funding.

To be eligible for either funding program, your organization must be a currently registered Registered Student Organization (RSO) with the Office of Student Engagement before submitting a Rolling Funding application or beginning to earn VIM volunteer hours.

[RSO Financial Policies](#)

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[Club Travel Guidelines](#)

[Club Tax Information](#)

[Meet with a Club Funding Assistant HERE!](#)

[Book A Meeting For CatServe Help](#)

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Types of Funds Available

[VIM Funding](#)

- VIM Funding is allocated on an ongoing basis to Registered Student Organizations **based upon their number of Volunteer Service Hours** to use in the current academic year.
- Each Volunteer hour earns the RSO \$15. A maximum of \$1500.00, or 100 hours can be earned per RSO.
- **Hours can be earned from April 1st through March 31st of each year.**
 - Hours gained after April 1st will be verified and money will be deposited into RSO accounts July 1st, or the next business day.
- Your organization must be a [registered student organization](#) with OSE to be eligible to collect Impact Hours toward VIM Funding.
- If you are allocated VIM funding, you are still eligible for Rolling funding.
- RSOs will track their service impacts via [CatServe](#).
- Club Funding Assistants will allocate funds on a bi-weekly basis based on accumulated volunteer hours on a first come, first serve basis. There will be no application process to access these funds.
- **Spending of Club funds shall be from July 1 through April 30th of each year.**

[Rolling Funding](#)

- Rolling Funding is based on an **Application Process** through the Finance Tab on CatsConnect (See below for details.)
- The Rolling Funding pool is available to Registered Student Organizations from mid-September to April 1st on a first-come, first-served basis.
- A maximum amount of \$13,500 may be awarded to a RSO from this pool of money each academic year.
- If the request is over \$9,999.00, the RSO will need to present to the ASMSU Senate for approval.
- Your organization must be a [registered student organization](#) with OSE to be eligible to request money through the Rolling Funding Process.
- If you are allocated Rolling funding, you are still eligible for VIM funding.
- The application will be reviewed by Club Funding Assistants and then the [Registered Student Organization Funding Board](#) at their weekly meeting. A short presentation to the board is suggested.
- **Spending of Club funds shall be from July 1 through April 30th of each year.**

[VIM Funding Details](#)

V.I.M. stands for: "Volunteer and Impact Montana"

VIM Funding Timeline

- **Collect Volunteer hours all year long!**

VIM Hours can be accumulated all year long. Money will be allocated to RSOs once the hours are double verified and will be first come first serve according to available funding.

Rules

- VIM Funding is allocated on an ongoing basis to Registered Student Organizations based upon their number of Volunteer Service Hours to use in the current academic year.
- A maximum of \$1500.00, or 100 hours can be earned per RSO.
- Spending can start July 1st at 8:00am and will end **April 30th** at 5:00pm.
- Your organization must be a [registered student organization](#) with OSE to be eligible to collect Impact Hours toward VIM Funding.
- If you are allocated VIM funding, you are still eligible for Rolling funding.
- RSOs will track their service impacts via [CatServe](#).
- Club Funding Assistants will allocate funds on a monthly basis based on accumulated volunteer hours on a first come, first serve basis. There will be no application process to access these funds.

Hours can be earned from April 1st through March 31st of each year. The Spending deadline is April 30th. Hours must be double verified by April 14 in order to be allocated by the April 30th Deadline. Hours gained after April 1st will be desposited into RSO accounts on July 1st or the next business day for use the next academic year.

VIM Funding Process

1. **Find Volunteer Hours.** Search for volunteer opportunities on [CatsConnect](#), [CatServe](#) or through the Office of Student Engagement.
1. **Log Volunteer Hours.** Individuals within organizations will track their volunteer hours for their club through the CatServe platform- each individual must be listed in the "membership Roster" on CatsConnect for their hours to count.
 - Eligible hours need to be: 1) Unpaid, 2) Within the State of Montana OR in association with MSU (ie: Engineers Without Borders, BreaksAway Trips, etc.).
 - Work done within your own club or another club does not count towards VIM (please contact the RSO program coordinator if you need to clarify if your club event counts as VIM or not).
 - Hours can only be counted toward one club at a time. If a club member is part of multiple clubs, they will choose which club received their hours.
 - Mandated service hours (University Conduct, Court-Ordered) do not count.
 - Hours can be accumulated between April 1st and ending March 31st of each year. This ensures time for double verification before the spending cycle ends.
 - A staff member from the Office of Student Engagement will double verify reported volunteer hours before they are applied to a RSO's VIM Bank.
 - Hours must be verifiable by a third party (Club members, leadership and advisors cannot verify hours within their own club).

What counts as volunteering?

1. Done within the State of Montana
 1. Or if the Volunteering hours are done as a representation of MSU. I.e.: MSU BreaksAway, Engineers without Borders, Club Trip with Volunteer component.
2. These opportunities MUST be unpaid.

How can I spend this money?

Funding earned can be spent in accordance to the mission and values of the club and however the RSO deems appropriate within the purchasing guidelines put forth by the ASMSU Business Office.

Steps to spend:

1. Submit a Purchase Request Form in CatsConnect. You can find this under the "Finance" tab. (More instructions are on the webpage below!)
 1. You can also make an appointment with a Club Funding Assistant to speak with them about your needs.
 2. **A purchase will NOT be made without a purchase request.**
2. Purchase Requests are reviewed in the order they are received. Requests submitted by the required deadline will be processed as quickly as possible.
 1. **RSOs must submit a purchase request at least 10 business days before items or services are needed. Food Purchase Requests must be submitted at least ten (10) business days before the event. For on-campus events, food must be purchased through University Catering or University Food Services in accordance with University policy unless a First Right of Refusal has been issued. Off-campus events may purchase food from any vendor.**
3. Items are shipped to ASMSU for pickup. Items need to be retrieved within 48 hours of notice. If items are not picked up promptly, ASMSU cannot guarantee storage space or responsibility for the items.

Important: Any funding an RSO is allocated is to be spent through ASMSU. The RSO does not get a check. RSOs will be required to go through a spending orientation before they are able to spend any funds. Reimbursements will not be approved, ASMSU will not approve items (including catering) for past events.

[We may have money leftover in our VIM account this year, can we use it next year?](#)

No, the money does not roll over year after year. You have until **April 30th**, to spend your money.

[If we receive VIM Funding, is that the only funding we can get?](#)

No, You may apply for Rolling Funding, too!

[What if our event is during the summer?](#)

Funding must be spent between July 1st and **April 30th** due to MSU's fiscal year calendar. If you are needing funds over the summer, reach out to ASMSU, and we will work with you!

[I have questions about my volunteer hours, where do I go?](#)

Please stop into the Office of Student Engagement - SUB 222! They can answer any questions you may have about your hours.

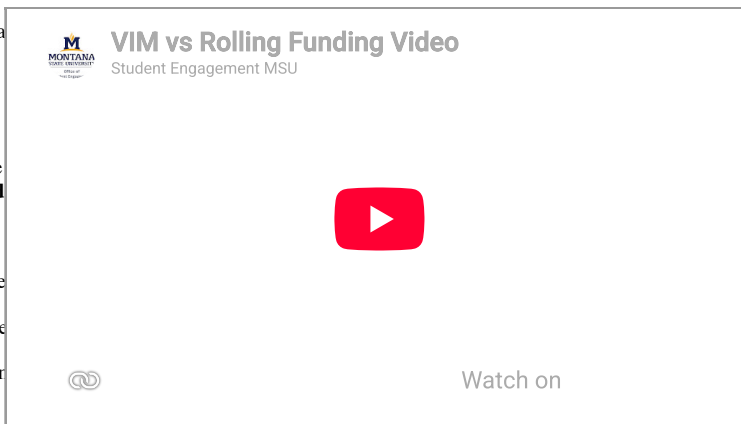
[Book A Meeting For CatServe Help](#)

[Rolling Funding Details](#)

Rolling Funding Rules

- The Rolling Funding pool is available to Registered Student Organizations from mid-September to April 30th.
- A maximum amount of **\$13,500** may be awarded to an RSO from this pool of money per academic year.
- If the request is over \$9,999.00, the RSO will need to present to the ASMSU Senate for approval.
- This pool of money will be spent within the current academic year, with a spending deadline of **April 30th**.
- These funds CANNOT fund programs.

The video explains the types of RSO funds available : VIM vs Rolling Funding



Rolling Funding Application Process

Step 1: Submit Application. Fill out the application and submit it to be SUBMITTED a MINIMUM of two weeks before the funding is needed.

To apply for funding:

- Log into [CatsConnect](#) and select the "Create New Request" button.
- Then, under "My Memberships", select "Create New Request" (this is where you can also find the "Create New Request" button).
- On the left side, click the pancake icon (this is where you can also find the "Create New Request" button).

- From the Finance Page, click "Create New Request" and select "Create Budget Request".
- Follow the steps in the application. You will get the chance to enter your line items for specific items in your request.
- [Instructions can also be found at this link.](#)

Step 2: Application Review. The Registered Student Organization Funding Board will meet to decide on funding allocations. Clubs are *encouraged* to send a representative to the Funding Board meeting to present* on their request. Organizations will be notified within one week of the Funding Board meeting if their funding application is approved and the total amount awarded. The Funding Board will **not** meet during university holidays or breaks. Your application will be accepted over breaks, but may take longer to review.

[Purchasing Process](#)

The presentation will last about 3-5 minutes. Please explain the use of funds, why the requested project is important to your club, how it meets your club's mission and values, and why it is a good investment of student-fee dollars. Please expect to answer questions from the RSO Funding Board regarding your request.

- Funding is approved.
- Complete Spending Orientation.
- Submit a Purchase Request.

Step 3: Schedule Spending Orientation. A representative from your organization (preferably Leader and/or Treasurer) must attend a meeting with an ASMSU Club Funding ASMSU representative to learn the process for spending your allocated money.

- Vendor ships or provides the service.
- Pick up items (if applicable).

[Student Rolling Application Approved Procedures](#)

Overview: You will get notified via email and CatsConnect.

[Before You Submit Your Purchase Request](#)

- Rolling funding is only available for funding requests to complete Funding & Spending Orientation (either in-person or online) before making a purchase.
- Purchase will NOT be made without a purchase request.
- Rolling funding is only available for funding requests to complete Funding & Spending Orientation (either in-person or online) before making a purchase.

A purchase will NOT be made without a purchase request.

Spending Orientation has been completed, order they are received. Requests submitted by the required deadline will be processed as quickly as possible.

- RSOs must submit a purchase request no less than **10 business days** before items are needed. **Food Purchase Requests must be submitted at least ten (10) business days before the event.** For one-time events, food must be purchased through University Catering or University Food Services in accordance with the University's policies.

- ✓ Even if the University of Montana is the first college in the state to be issued a First Right of Refusal, off-campus RSOs may purchase food from any vendor. fund to the level expected,
 - RSOs are shipped to a pickup location.
- ✓ Questions must be resolved within 48 hours of notification.
 - The appeal process shall be as follows:
- ✓ Food orders follow University food service requirements
 - Meet with the Presiding Chair or the Advisory Member of the RSOFB.
- ✓ Funds are available in your account
 - Make a formal written appeal and make the corrections as outlined by the Funding Board. **MUST be made within ONE WEEK of being notified.**

All purchase requests must be submitted at least **10 business days in advance** of when items or services are needed. **Regardless of event location, all food purchase requests must be submitted to the ASMSU Business Office at least ten (10) business days prior to the event.**

Business days are Monday–Friday and do not include weekends or university holidays. The day you submit your request does not count toward the 10 business days. Requests submitted fewer than 10 business days in advance are not guaranteed to be approved and may be denied. Plan ahead—submitting early ensures we can process your request and work with campus partners in a timely manner.

ASMSU purchases through approved university vendors whenever possible.

Funding earned can be spent in accordance to the mission and values of the club and however the RSO deems appropriate within the purchasing guidelines put forth by the ASMSU Business Office.

How do you spend club money?

If your preferred vendor is unavailable, the Business Office will work with you to identify an alternative.

- Spend between July 1st – April 30th of each year.

Approved Vendors: You may use your Club Funding Assistant to purchase items.

- A purchase will NOT be made without a purchase request.
- Submit a Purchase Request Form in CatsConnect. (You can find this under the "Finance" tab. (More instructions are on the webpage below!))
- Once it is lost it is lost and funds do not roll over year to year. Spending deadline is April 30th.
- You can also make an appointment with a Club Funding Assistant to speak with them about your needs.
- Must follow MSU purchasing guidelines.
- Staples **A purchase will NOT be made without a purchase request.**

Important: Purchase Requests are reviewed in the order they are received. Requests submitted by the required deadline will be processed as quickly as possible.

Important: RSOs must submit a purchase request at least **10 business days before items or services are needed. Food Purchase Requests must be submitted at least ten (10) business days before the event. For on-campus events, food must be purchased through University Catering or University Food Services**

Reimbursement is not available for off-campus events. **Reimbursement is not available for off-campus events. Reimbursement is not available for off-campus events.**

- Del. unavailability with University of Montana unless a First Right of Refusal has been issued. Off-campus events may purchase food from any vendor.
- B&H Photo

Important: Any funding an RSO is allocated is to be spent through ASMSU. The RSO does not get a check. RSOs will be required to go through a spending orientation before they are able to spend any funds. Reimbursements will not be paid. ASMSU will not approve items (including catering) for past events.

We may have money leftover in our Rolling account this year, can we use it next year?

To purchase items / pay vendors:

No, the money does not roll over year after year. You have until **April 30th**, to spend your money.

- Henry Shien
- Must fill out a Purchase Request in CatsConnect.

Additionally, an RSO may not spend Rolling funding in another manner other than what is approved by Funding Board.

- MSU Industrial Supply Company
- ASMSU pays bills on your behalf.

Examples: Paying a vendor equipment/materials purchased from a business, MSU Catering.

If we have Rolling Funding, is that the only funding we can get?

Invoices:

No! You are also eligible for up to \$1,500.00 of VIM Funding!

- All on-campus vendors will invoice you.
- Fisher Scientific
- Submit the bill/invoice to ASMSU as soon as possible to avoid late fees.

What if our event is during the summer?

- Lowe's

Travel: Funding must be spent between July 1st and **April 30th** due to MSU's fiscal year calendar. If you are needing funds over the summer, reach out to ASMSU, and we will work with you on travel section below!

- Amazon

Food & Catering:

- Millipore Sigma
- McMaster-Carr
- Includes pre-ordering off-campus food and catering for events.
- For on-campus events, food must be purchased through MSU Catering or University Food Services in accordance with University policy. If University Food Services issues a First Right of Refusal, food may then be purchased from another vendor.
- Must follow MSU policies and timelines.
- **Regardless of event location, all food purchase requests must be submitted to the ASMSU Business Office at least ten (10) business days prior to the event.**
- Uline

***** Food purchases do not need to adhere to these vendors.**

Notes:

If your vendor isn't listed:

- Money does not go to the club - it is paid directly to the vendor.
- Late or incomplete requests may be denied.
- Email clubs@montana.edu for support.
- Do not pay out of pocket or use unapproved websites.
- **A purchase will NOT be made without a purchase request.**

Contract Signing and MSU Funds

Students are not authorized to sign contracts on behalf of Montana State University or ASMSU.

Registered Student Organizations **cannot sign any contracts** using MSU money. Before committing to *any* agreement, you **must speak with a Club Funding Assistant** to get proper approval.

Important: Any contract signed without prior approval **will not be eligible for funding**. Always get guidance first to ensure your club's spending complies with university policy.

Reimbursements

Policy Shift:

Tips & Tricks

As of the 2025-2026 academic year, RSOs **cannot** purchase items with personal funds and seek reimbursement.

Why this change? The Funding Board will not accept funding application requests for programs/events/activities that have already occurred.

- Reimbursements will not be approved, ASMSU will not approve items (including catering) for past events.
 - RSOs must submit a purchase request at least 10 business days before items or services are needed. Food Purchase Requests must be submitted at least ten (10) business days before the event. For on-campus events, food must be purchased through University Catering or University Food Services in accordance with University policy unless a First Right of Refusal has been issued. Off-campus events may purchase food from any vendor.
 - Reimbursement of funds
 - A purchase will NOT be made without a purchase request.
 - Increases accessibility (no one should have to front club money).
 - Plan ahead if you want to order any items that are personalized. For example, if you choose to order shirts from Custom Ink, it could take up to 5 weeks to complete your order.
 - Ensures tax compliance and audit protection.
- It is highly recommended your club plans well in advance and have time to send your application to ASMSU for review before final submission. You can email your application (using the Save and Resume later option) to clubs@montana.edu.
- If you purchase something without approval, it is at your own risk and likely not reimbursable.**
- Be thorough and have others look over your document. The Funding Board wants quality applications and an incomplete application will hinder your chances of receiving funding.

Campus Sponsorships for Clubs

If a club has secured a sponsorship from a generous campus entity, the campus department can pay that sponsorship in the following ways:

1. The campus department can pay the invoice on the club's behalf.
 - Please work with ASMSU if the invoice amount is over the sponsorship amount. If the club has adequate funding through ASMSU, we will pay the difference.
- OR**
2. The campus department can transfer the sponsorship money to an ASMSU index **PLUS the 6%** mandatory transfer fee.
 - Please work with ASMSU to obtain the index.

As part of the sponsorship agreement, campus entities will be responsible for processing the sponsorship payment, including filling out a Campus Hospitality Form (HAF), if needed.

Other Sponsorships

If your club is receiving money from a sponsor (outside of ASMSU Rolling or VIM funding), here's what you need to know:

MSU cannot hold this money for you

Montana State University cannot hold outside sponsorship funds for clubs or act as a bank on your behalf. This means sponsorship money cannot be sent to MSU or ASMSU to sit in a university account.

Personal bank accounts cannot be used

A personal bank account belongs to one individual, and legally the funds in that account belong to that person.

A club bank account, on the other hand, belongs to the organization. It allows multiple officers to access the account and ensures the money belongs to the club, not to one student.

To avoid ownership confusion and financial risk, sponsorship funds should never be deposited into a personal account.

So where should the money go?

If your club plans to accept outside sponsorship funds, you will need to deposit them into a club bank account.

To open a club bank account, the bank will require your organization to have a Federal Employer Identification Number (EIN). An EIN is a number issued by the Internal Revenue Service that allows an organization to open a bank account.

Obtaining an EIN does **not** automatically mean your club owes taxes. It is simply an identification number used for banking and reporting purposes.

Instructions for applying for an EIN are available below.

Once you receive the EIN, you can take that documentation to the bank of your choice to open an account in the club's name.

Is this required?

Opening a bank account and obtaining an EIN is optional overall. However, if your club would like to receive and deposit outside sponsorship funds, a club bank account is necessary since MSU cannot hold the funds and personal accounts cannot be used.

Important responsibility information

If your club chooses to open and maintain a bank account:

- The club is fully responsible for managing those funds
- The club is responsible for maintaining records and completing any required tax filings
- Associated Students of Montana State University (ASMSU), the Office of Student Engagement, and Montana State University are not responsible for how the funds are managed
- ASMSU and OSE do not track EIN numbers or off-campus bank account information

If you would like additional guidance, you may schedule an appointment with ASMSU Legal Services here:

<https://asmsulegalservices.org/>

Funding FAQs

What am I prohibited to buy?

The following items are **not allowed** to be purchased using RSO funds. This list is **not exhaustive** and all purchases must comply with university policies.

Prohibited Expenses

Substances and Regulated Items

- Alcohol, tobacco, marijuana, or any controlled substances

Donations, Gifts, and Personal Benefit

- Philanthropic donations, charitable contributions, or gifts to organizations or individuals
- Personal gifts, awards, or items for individual benefit to members, advisors, or officers
- Scholarships, stipends, cash awards, or financial incentives
- Gift cards, prepaid cards, vouchers, or any items that function as cash or cash-equivalent value (no exceptions)

Taxes, Fees, and Financial Liabilities

- State or federal taxes, IRS filing fees, or tax reinstatement fees
- Bank account fees (initial deposits, overdraft fees, monthly maintenance fees, etc.)
- Monetary investment funds or savings accounts
- Fines, penalties, late fees, damage fees, or cancellation fees resulting from negligence or policy violations

Payments to Individuals

- Payment to members of the organization for any purpose
- Hiring staff or paying salaries under the RSO banner (unless explicitly approved by the ASMSU Business Office)

Purchasing & Procurement Restrictions

- Items purchased or events held before funding approval (no reimbursements for past expenses)
- Purchases made without an approved purchase request
- Used items or purchases through informal or unverified marketplaces (e.g., Facebook Marketplace, Craigslist)
- Multiple transactions intended to bypass funding limits, approval thresholds, or procurement requirements
- Subscriptions, memberships, or recurring services without prior approval (e.g., streaming platforms, software, cloud storage)
- Ongoing financial obligations without prior approval from the RSO Funding Board and ASMSU Business Office

Programmatic and Mission Alignment

- Social events or functions not connected to an educational, programmatic, or mission-driven activity
- Expenses that exclusively benefit club leadership (e.g., executive meals, apparel, closed retreats) unless explicitly approved

- Any item or activity deemed excessive, unjustified, or inconsistent with the club's mission

Assets and High-Risk Items

- Vehicles, trailers, livestock, or live animals
- Drones
- Firearms and ammunition (excluding approved targets and firearm accessories)

Reimbursements will not be approved, ASMSU will not approve items (including catering) for past events.

A purchase will NOT be made without a purchase request.

What items can I buy?

RSO funds may be used for expenses that directly support the organization's mission and approved activities, as long as they are reasonable, necessary, and comply with university policies. Examples include:

Permitted Expenses

- Event supplies and materials for approved programs and activities
- Advertising, printing, and marketing materials for RSO events
- Modest food and refreshments for general meetings or events open to members or the public (in compliance with University Facilities Use Manual 800.00)
- Travel expenses for approved conferences, competitions, or official organizational business (must follow university travel policies)
- Honoraria or payments to guest speakers, performers, or outside contractors providing services to the organization
- Uniforms, apparel, or supplies used for official RSO representation (must comply with university vendor and trademark regulations)

RSOs must submit a purchase request at least 10 business days before items or services are needed. Food Purchase Requests must be submitted at least ten (10) business days before the event. For on-campus events, food must be purchased through University Catering or University Food Services in accordance with University policy unless a First Right of Refusal has been issued. Off-campus events may purchase food from any vendor.

1. A purchase will NOT be made without a purchase request.

Who can purchase items?

Club leadership must work with Club Funding Assistants to make purchases. Start by submitting a Purchase Request Form in CatsConnect.

RSOs must submit a purchase request at least 10 business days before items or services are needed. Food Purchase Requests must be submitted at least ten (10) business days before the event. For on-campus events, food must be purchased through University Catering or University Food Services in accordance with University policy unless a First Right of Refusal has been issued. Off-campus events may purchase food from any vendor.

1. A purchase will NOT be made without a purchase request.

When do I need to submit a purchase request?

All club purchases must be submitted **at least 10 business days in advance** of your event or the date the item/service is needed.

This 10-day timeline allows our team and campus partners to:

- Review requests for compliance with university policies
- Coordinate with vendors (including catering, printing, and services)
- Process payments and required approvals
- Ensure orders can be completed accurately and on time

What does "10 business days" mean?

Business days are Monday–Friday and do not include weekends or university holidays. The day you submit your request does not count toward the 10 business days.

Why is this important?

Submitting late requests limits what we can approve and often results in delays, denials, or reduced options. Our office will no longer be able to accommodate last-minute exceptions.

What happens if I miss the deadline?

Requests submitted fewer than 10 business days in advance are **not guaranteed to be approved** and may be denied to remain in compliance with university policy and campus partner timelines.

Helpful tip:

If you're planning an event, submit your purchase request as soon as possible—even if some details are still being finalized. It's always easier to adjust a request than to rush one at the last minute.

Does my club qualify for Rolling Funding?

If you are a current registered student organization, then YES! you are qualified for Rolling Funding!

[Can we ask for money for food?](#)

Yes! If your event involves food and is on campus, you must order through University Catering. Submit a Purchase Request in CatsConnect. A Club Funding Assistant will review your request and contact you if additional information is needed..

Exception: Orders of five (5) pizzas or fewer may be purchased from an outside vendor, consistent with current University food service policy. Orders of six (6) pizzas or more, and all other food purchases for on-campus events, shall be provided or approved by University Catering.

Regardless of event location, all food purchase requests must be submitted to the ASMSU Business Office at least ten (10) business days prior to the event.

If Your event is off-campus, you do not need to use University catering. Submit a Purchase Request in CatsConnect. A Club Funding Assistant will review your request and contact you if additional information is needed..

RSOs must submit a purchase request at least 10 business days before items or services are needed. Food Purchase Requests must be submitted at least ten (10) business days before the event. For on-campus events, food must be purchased through University Catering or University Food Services in accordance with University policy unless a First Right of Refusal has been issued. Off-campus events may purchase food from any vendor.

1. A purchase will NOT be made without a purchase request.

[Where does the student organization money come from?](#)

Every fee-paying student pays \$11.13/semester as part of their student fees.

[How do I apply for rolling funding?](#)

[All funding applications are on CatsConnect.](#) Clubs can apply for funding through their organization's page on CatsConnect. They will have to click on the Manage tab on the club page, click on the pancake icon on the top left (three stacked lines), scroll down and click on "Finance", click the "Create New Request" dropdown menu on the top right, and click "Create Budget Request".

[What if we don't get our Rolling Funding application in by the weekly deadline?](#)

Rolling funding will have a weekly deadline throughout the academic year.

Submit your application by Mondays at Noon.

If you miss the weekly deadline for Rolling Funding, get your application in by the next week. Reminder you must get your application in AT LEAST 2 weeks before your funding need.

[Rolling Funding Restrictions](#)

Rolling Funding may only be used for the items approved by the RSO Funding Board. If your purchase needs change, contact the ASMSU Business Office before submitting a Purchase Request.

[My club was allocated money, now what?](#)

You can meet with an ASMSU Funding Assistant to learn how to spend your money, or submit a purchase request on CatsConnect.

[Meet with a Club Funding Assistant HERE!](#)

[What if I need something sooner?](#)

Purchase Requests submitted fewer than ten (10) business days before they are needed may be denied. Expedited processing cannot be guaranteed.

[What is the deadline to spend the money?](#)

You have until April 30th to spend any money that was allocated. Money does not roll over.

1. A purchase will NOT be made without a purchase request.

[How do we check our balance and statuses of applications?](#)

To view your organization's account:

- Log into [CatsConnect](#) and select the waffle (grid) icon in the top right corner and click "Manage".
- Then, under "My Memberships", select your organization.
- On the left side, click the pancake menu (three stacked lines), and then select "Finance" under Organization Tools. (this menu is also your main control center for all club operations!)
- Then, you'll see three tabs on the left side of the page, Budget, Purchase, and Funding. By selecting,
 - The Budget tab, you will see all of your Budget Requests and the stage they are in.

- The Purchase tab, you will see all of your Purchase Requests and the stage they are in.
- The Funding tab, you will see all of your Funding applications.
- You will also see two tabs on the right, Accounts and Create New Request. The Create New Request tab is a dropdown menu for Create Budget Request and Create Purchase Request. By selecting,
 - The Accounts tab, you'll see your funding balance! Please note, if you had submitted receipts within 48-hours, your account balance may not reflect those receipts.
 - The Create Budget Request tab, you will be able to apply for either Rolling or Matching Funding. This is where the Mass Funding application will appear every Spring.
 - The Create Purchase Request tab, you will be able to fill out the Purchase Request form for **reimbursement or invoices only**.

NOTE: Your CatsConnect balance may not update immediately after purchases while invoices are processing.

What if we go over budget?

Plan ahead! Your group is responsible for any expenses incurred over your allocated amount.

If the final purchase price exceeds the approved funding amount, the organization is responsible for covering the difference.

If the purchase exceeds the organization's available account balance, the organization must reimburse ASMSU within ten (10) business days for the overdrawn amount.

What if we don't plan to spend all our money?

Notify us if you don't plan on spending all and we can re-allocate to another club. The allocated money will not roll over from year to year.

Can I be reimbursed?

No. There will be no reimbursements for personal spending- all spending must go through ASMSU.

ASMSU will not approve items (including catering) for past events.

Can we return an item we purchased?

Returns or exchanges are generally not permitted unless an item arrives damaged or is covered by the vendor's warranty.

Club Travel Guidelines

Before You Travel (Planning & Approval)

Do we need approval to travel?

Yes.

All club travel must be approved by your **club advisor and the ASMSU Business** before you go - even if you are not using student-fee dollars to travel.

Do we need approval for local trips (like to Hyalite)?

Yes.

If you leave campus with your club, you must submit a travel form.

What is a Travel Form?

It's the main form that tells MSU:

- Who is going
- Where you are going
- When you are traveling
- Who is responsible

You must submit this **for every off-campus trip**.

- **Day Travel Form:** Required for any day travel. Must be filled out 10 business days in advance. **If you are within the 10-business-day period of travel, you may be refused funding, have your organization frozen, and/or face disciplinary action per MSU Policy.**
- **Overnight Travel form:** For any overnight stay. Lists hotels and contact info for safety tracking. Must be filled out 10 business days in advance.
- **Participant Travel form:** Each traveling member will need to fill out a participant travel form once per year.
- **International Travel Registration:** If traveling outside the U.S., register with the Office of International Programs at least 60 days in advance.

What is a Trip Coordinator?

For trips with **4 or more students**, you must choose a Trip Coordinator.
They handle:

- Planning
- Communication
- Emergency contacts
- Safety coordination

You list them on the travel form.

Can we book travel before approval?

No.
Do not book flights, hotels, or cars before you are approved. If you are using RSO Club funding, you must also submit a purchase request.

Do Club Sports have extra requirements?

Yes.
Club Sports must also work with Campus Recreation for travel approval and requirements.

Required Forms (What Paperwork Do We Submit?)

What forms do we need for travel?

You may need several forms depending on your trip:

- Master Travel Form (every trip)
- Day Travel Form (same-day trips)
- Overnight Travel Form (if staying overnight)
- Participant Travel Form (each traveler, once per year)
- International Travel Registration (for trips outside the U.S.)
- **Day Travel Form:** Required for any day travel. Must be filled out 10 business days in advance. **If you are within the 10-business-day period of travel, you may be refused funding, have your organization frozen, and/or face disciplinary action per MSU Policy.**
- **Overnight Travel form:** For any overnight stay. Lists hotels and contact info for safety tracking. Must be filled out 10 business days in advance.
- **Participant Travel form:** Each traveling member will need to fill out a participant travel form once per year.
- **International Travel Registration:** If traveling outside the U.S., register with the Office of International Programs at least 60 days in advance.

What is the Day Travel Form?

Use this for trips where you **leave and return the same day**.
Must be submitted **10 business days before travel**.

Day Travel Form

What is the Overnight Travel Form?

Use this if you are **staying anywhere overnight**.
Includes hotel and emergency contact information.
Must be submitted **10 business days before travel**.

Overnight Travel form

What is the Participant Travel Form?

Each traveler fills this out **once per year**.
It includes emergency contact and liability information.

[Participant Travel form](#)

[What if we submit forms late?](#)

Late forms may result in:

- Denied funding
- Organization freeze
- Disciplinary action (per MSU policy)

[What if we are traveling internationally?](#)

You must register with the [Office of International Programs](#) at least **60 days in advance**. ASMSU does **not** fund international travel.

[Paying for Travel \(Funding & Booking\)](#)

[Can we use club funds to pay for club travel?](#)

ASMSU may fund **approved travel inside the United States**, depending on your funding source and approval.

[What travel costs can be covered?](#)

Common examples:

- Rental vehicles
 - Gas cards
 - Gas cards can only be used for rental vehicles, not personal vehicles.
- Hotels
- Flights
- Conference registration

[What travel costs can't be covered?](#)

Common examples:

- Uber/Lift/taxi rides
- Food
- Room damages

[How do we book flights, hotels, or cars?](#)

First, submit a purchase request.

Once a Club Funding Assistant received the request, we will reach out with any questions.

NEVER book travel on your own if you are using club funding.

[What is a Purchase Request?](#)

A Purchase Request is required **before ASMSU can pay for anything**. No purchase will be made without an approved request.

See above more more details on how to submit.

[Can we get reimbursed if we booked before approval?](#)

No.

If you book before approval, ASMSU will not be able to reimburse you.

[We aren't using rental cars to travel. Can we get reimbursed for gas?](#)

No.

The preferred method for car travel is rental cars. If an RSO chooses to drive personal vehicles, there will not be reimbursement for gas or mileage.

[Transportation & Safety](#)

[Who can drive university or rental vehicles?](#)

- Only **authorized drivers** can drive MSU vehicles
 - Please visit [MSU's Rental Car Policy](#) for more information.
- Rental car drivers must be **21 or older**
- Non-MSU participants cannot drive unless officially approved.

[View State of Montana Vehicle Use Policy HERE](#)

[Can we drive personal cars?](#)

Yes.

But mileage and gas are not reimbursed.

[Is our club responsible for the rental car insurance deductible?](#)

Yes.

Departments or units renting vehicles through Enterprise will be responsible for paying the insurance deductible (up to \$1,500) if MSU is found liable for damage to the vehicle.

ASMSU will pass this deductible on to the club. RSOs can not use club funds to cover this expense.

[Do we have to wear seatbelts?](#)

Yes. Seatbelts are required at all times.

[Can we use gas cards for personal cars?](#)

No.

Gas cards are **only for rental vehicles**.

[How do we reserve a gas card?](#)

Funding Assistants can rent you a car through Enterprise. You can also reserve a gas card through the "Gas Card Request Form"

[Enterprise/Gas Card Request Form](#)

[Where can we find rental car rules?](#)

See [MSU's Rental Car Policy](#) for full details.

[View State of Montana Vehicle Use Policy HERE](#)

[What safety information should we have when we travel?](#)

- Emergency contacts
- Lodging details
- Travel routes
- Health insurance information for each traveler

[Behavior, Risk & Communication](#)

[How should we behave while traveling?](#)

You represent **MSU and your club**.

Follow university policies, local laws, and act professionally.

[Who should we communicate with during travel?](#)

Stay in contact with:

- Your Trip Coordinator
- Your club advisor

Share itineraries and emergency contacts before leaving.

What if there is an emergency?

Contact local law enforcement, your advisor, Trip Coordinator, and MSU Dean of Students Office immediately.

Dean of Students:

SUB Room 174

deanofstudents@montana.edu

or call us at (406) 994-2826

After the Trip

What do we do after returning?

- Share feedback with your advisor
- Tell your club how it went!

Quick Reference

- Travel must be approved **before** any bookings.
- Submit the correct **Travel Authorization Form** via CatsConnect for *any* travel.
- Each traveling member will need to fill out a participant travel form once per year.
- Work with staff to book:
 - Flights
 - Hotels
 - Vehicles
- **A purchase will NOT be made without a purchase request.**
- **ASMSU will only fund travel inside the United States.**

Club Sports: Work with campus Recreation to complete special travel requirements.

Club Taxes

Optional: How to Obtain a Tax ID Number

A Tax ID Number or EIN (Employer ID Number) is like a social security number for your organization. Student organizations are often in situations that require a Federal Tax ID Number (opening an organizational bank account, conducting fundraisers, receiving reimbursement if allocated money through the student organization fee, etc.). Registered student organizations are not permitted to use the MSU's tax identification number; therefore, they are required to obtain their own EIN. The purpose of the EIN is so the IRS will not make any organization members personally responsible for taxes on revenue that the organization has earned.

[Make an appointment with ASMSU Legal Services HERE](#)

Please note: Applying for an EIN and/or opening an off-campus bank account is completely optional for registered student organizations. Clubs are not required to do either.

If a club chooses to apply for an EIN or maintain an off-campus bank account, all related responsibilities including cash handling, financial transparency, stewardship of funds, recordkeeping, and any required tax filings are the responsibility of the club and its members.

ASMSU, the Office of Student Engagement (OSE), and Montana State University are not responsible for a club's financial actions or inaction, including banking practices, tax compliance, or IRS reporting. Additionally, ASMSU and OSE do not track EIN numbers or off-campus bank account information for registered student organizations.

Tax Exemption

Student organization registration with the Office of Student Engagement does not imply tax exemption. Only College departments and offices may use MSU's tax ID number.

[Make an appointment with ASMSU Legal Services HERE](#)

Apply for an EIN Online

The following steps were written to assist a registered student organization with applying for an EIN online. If you have any technical issues or have questions regarding the form, please refer to the IRS' help and support services.

1. Go to the IRS' Apply for an Employer Identification Number (EIN) online website.
2. Click the APPLY for an EIN Online link. Click the Apply Online Now button.
3. Once you have read the instructions on the page, click the Begin Application button.
4. Select the View Additional Types, Including Tax-Exempt and Governmental Organizations option for the "What type of legal structure is applying for an EIN?" question and then click the Continue button.
 1. IMPORTANT: Any of the following options may describe your type of organization: 1) Political Organization; 2) Church-Controlled Organization; 3) Community or Volunteer Group; 4) Social or Savings Club; or 5) Sports Teams (community).
5. Once your selection is made, click on the Continue button. Confirm the type. Click Continue.
6. Select "Banking Purposes". Select Individual. Fill out your information or advisor/another officer information. Enter your first name, last name, and SSN/ITIN. Preferably, enter your on-campus address. This may be your advisor's or your SUB mailbox. You may also use the Office of Student Engagement Address: 222 Strand Union Building or 751 W. Grant St., Bozeman, MT 59717
7. Next page is verifying address. Enter your information. DO NOT put MSU or Montana State in front of your club name. For example, DO NOT say MSU Social club. Instead use, Social Club or Social Club of MSU.
8. Enter the requested information about your organization and click the Continue button when you are done.
9. Repeat this step for the next screen requesting additional organizational information.
10. Select the Other option for the question "What does your business or organization do?" and click the Continue button. Select the Organization option for the question regarding your business activity and click the Continue button. From the list of organizational activities select the activity that best describes what your organization does (most organizations will select the Social or Civic option) and click the Continue button. If you are unsure, Social or Civic is a good option.
 1. IMPORTANT: Select Receive Letter Online. DO NOT choose receive by mail. Once you receive the information, retain it in your student organization files for current and future leadership. Hit Continue until confirmation that you have finished and completed the form.

[Make an appointment with ASMSU Legal Services HERE](#)

Optional: Student Organization Bank Account Instructions

Opening a RSO bank account is optional.

However, a RSO may want one to hold fundraised money, or membership dues.

What is required to open an account for a Student Organization:

1. MSU Office of Student Engagement recognition letter
2. Tax Identification Number/Entity Identification Number (EIN) obtained from the IRS
3. Two organization representatives must be signers, one of whom MUST be an advisor
4. Minutes from a recent meeting stating who the current officers are, that a bank account at First Interstate will be opened, and who the authorized signers on the account will be
5. All signers' information is required before the account can be opened
 1. Name, date of birth, social security number, physical address, and two forms of identification
6. Initial deposit of \$100.00

RSOs are not allowed to use personal bank accounts for RSO funds. If your club has an external bank account, it must be managed responsibly.

[Make an appointment with ASMSU Legal Services HERE](#)

Please note: Applying for an EIN and/or opening an off-campus bank account is completely optional for registered student organizations. Clubs are not required to do either.

If a club chooses to apply for an EIN or maintain an off-campus bank account, all related responsibilities including cash handling, financial transparency, stewardship of funds, recordkeeping, and any required tax filings are the responsibility of the club and its members.

ASMSU, the Office of Student Engagement (OSE), and Montana State University are not responsible for a club's financial actions or inaction, including banking practices, tax compliance, or IRS reporting.

Additionally, ASMSU and OSE do not track EIN numbers or off-campus bank account information for registered student organizations.

Does our club need to file taxes?

Only if your club has its own EIN (separate from MSU). If you use RSO Club funds through ASMSU, you do not file.

[Make an appointment with ASMSU Legal Services HERE](#)

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Could we use club funds to pay IRS filing or reinstatement fees?

No. Student fees cannot be used to pay IRS filing, application, or reinstatement fees for independent student organizations.

ASMSU will not pay for:

- Form 1023 or 1023-EZ (applying for 501(c)(3) status)
- Form 1024 (applying for other tax-exempt statuses, like 501(c)(7))
- Form 8976 (501(c)(4) notification)
- Reinstatement after loss of tax-exempt status IRS penalties, late fees, or interest
- Any taxes owed
- Legal or accounting costs related to missed filings or noncompliance

These are considered legal and tax compliance costs for your organization, not student programming expenses.

Why ASMSU cannot pay these fees

- 1) Student fees are restricted funds ASMSU funds come from student fees and must be used for student programs, events, and services - not legal or tax obligations of separate organizations.
- 2) Independent clubs are separate legal entities If your club has its own EIN, it is legally separate from Montana State University and ASMSU. That means the club, not the university, is responsible for its filings and costs.
- 3) Audit and compliance risk Using student fees to pay private organization tax costs could raise concerns in audits and may lead to restrictions on future funding policies.

What ASMSU can help with

Even though Club Fund cannot be used for these costs, ASMSU can:

- Provide guidance on what forms to file and when
- Offer treasurer training and compliance workshops
- Share templates, reminders, and checklists
- Help clubs decide whether maintaining separate tax status is the right choice

[Make an appointment with ASMSU Legal Services HERE](#)

What forms do independent clubs have to file?

Usually a Form 990, 990-EZ, or 990-N every year.

[Make an appointment with ASMSU Legal Services HERE](#)

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Additionally, ASMSU and OSE do not track EIN numbers or off-campus bank account information for registered student organizations.

What happens if our club doesn't file taxes?

The IRS automatically revokes your tax-exempt status.

[Make an appointment with ASMSU Legal Services HERE](#)

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Additionally, ASMSU and OSE do not track EIN numbers or off-campus bank account information for registered student organizations.

[Who should we contact for tax-related questions?](#)

Please visit our ASMSU Legal Services website or make an appointment to talk with a lawyer for FREE! We can help with training, reminders, filing guidance, templates, and officer transition support.

[Make an appointment with ASMSU Legal Services HERE](#)

ASMSU

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